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California General Election: Key Dates and Statewide Propositions

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California General Election: Key Dates and Statewide Propositions

By ANGELINA PARISI and ADENIYI LATINWO

California's general election is approaching, with voters set to cast their ballots Nov. 3. As Election Day draws closer, several important dates, deadlines and Statewide ballot propositions are on the calendars and minds for voters.

Proposition 1: Housing Bond

What it would do: Proposition 1 would authorize the state to issue $11.25 billion in general obligation bonds for housing programs. The money would be divided among multifamily rental housing, affordable housing preservation and supportive housing, veterans' mortgages, homeownership and down-payment assistance, farmworker, tribal and student housing, housing infrastructure and local housing programs. The measure would cost the state an estimated $500 million to $600 million annually for about 25 years to repay the bonds.

Support

Supporters, including US Vets, the California Federation of Teachers, Habitat for Humanity California and Self-Help for the Elderly, say the measure would expand affordable housing for veterans, seniors, people with disabilities and working families. They also argue that the bond would help expand homeownership and prevent homelessness while providing funding without raising taxes.

Opposition

No argument against Proposition 1 was submitted for the official voter guide.

Supporters:

US VetsCA Federation of TeachersSelf-Help for the ElderlyHabitat for Humanity CACA Alliance of Child & Family Services

No opponents were listed.

Proposition 2: Rainy Day Fund

What it would do: Proposition 2 would change California's rules for saving money during periods of strong state revenue. It would require the state to continue making deposits into its main rainy day fund until the fund reaches 20% of General Fund tax revenue, compared with the current 10% threshold. It also would require additional debt payments through 2040, extending the current requirement that is scheduled to end in 2030. Deposits into the rainy day fund and a separate account used to set aside money during revenue surges would not count toward the state's constitutional spending limit until the money is withdrawn.

Support

Supporters, including the California Professional Firefighters, Los Angeles Area Chamber of Commerce and Gov.

Gavin Newsom, say the measure would strengthen the state's financial reserves and help protect funding for education, health care, public safety and other services during economic downturns. Supporters also argue that increasing the reserve would help the state avoid sharp spending cuts when revenue falls.

Opposition

Opponents argue that the measure would effectively allow the state to set aside more money outside the constitutional spending limit and could make taxpayer rebates less likely. They also say the measure does not directly provide new funding for education, health care or public safety.

Supporters:

CA Professional Firefighters LA Chamber of Commerce Gavin Newsom Xavier Becerra Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel

No opponents were listed.

Proposition 3: High-Income Tax

What it would do: Proposition 3 would make permanent existing voter-approved higher income tax rates for Californians earning more than $371,000, with the income threshold adjusted annually for inflation. The tax rates were approved in 2012 and are scheduled to expire in 2031. The measure is estimated to maintain between $5 billion and $15 billion in annual state income tax revenue. Roughly 40% of the revenue would go to schools and community colleges, with the remainder supporting other state programs.

Support

Supporters, including the California Teachers Association, California School Nurses Organization and California State PTA, say keeping the higher tax rates would protect funding for schools and health care. They argue the measure would prevent a tax reduction for the state's highest-income earners while maintaining money for public services.

Opposition

Opponents, including the California Taxpayers Association, Family Business Association of California and California Hispanic Chambers of Commerce, argue that California already has high taxes and a high cost of living. They say the state should address spending and government programs before making the higher income tax rates permanent.

Supporters:

California Teachers AssociationCA School Nurses Organization California State PTA Planned Parenthood Affiliates of CA

Opponents:

California Taxpayers AssociationFamily Business Association of California California Hispanic Chambers of Commerce

Proposition 4: Public Campaign Financing

What it would do:

PROP 4 would allow California state and local governments to establish public campaign-financing programs for candidates if they choose to do so. The measure would reverse a 1988 ban on such systems for the state and most

local governments. Currently, five California cities, including Berkeley and San Francisco, have public financing for local offices.

Support

Supporters say public campaign financing could reduce the influence of private money in politics, arguing that publicly funded campaigns could encourage candidates without significant financial backing to run for office and give small-dollar donors a greater role.

Opposition:

Opponents say the measure could require taxpayers to subsidize candidates they do not support and could direct public money to fraudulent candidates. They also argue that establishing public-financing systems could be costly for state and local governments.

Supporters:

Laurel Plimier, co-president, League of Women Voters of CaliforniaTom Umberg, California state senator

Opponents:

Dan Schnur, Former Chair Fair Political Practices Commission Colleen McAndrews, Former Commissioner Fair Political Practices Commission

Proposition 5: Recall Elections

What it would do: Proposition 5 would change the process for replacing statewide elected officials who are recalled. Under current law, recall elections ask voters two questions: whether an official should be removed and who should replace the official. Proposition 5 would remove the second question. If the governor is recalled, the lieutenant governor would become governor for the remainder of the term or until a successor is elected, depending on when the recall occurs. For other recalled state officials, the vacancy would generally be filled through a subsequent special election or appointment under existing vacancy rules.

Support

Supporters argue that the measure would return the recall process to its primary purpose of deciding whether an elected official should be removed. They say the current replacement system can allow a candidate to win with only a small share of the vote because multiple candidates can divide the vote in a recall election. Supporters also argue that a separate process for selecting replacements would reduce the political component of recalls.

Opposition

Opponents argue that the measure would remove voters' ability to select a replacement at the same time they decide whether to recall an official. They say the proposal could result in politicians selecting replacements for some statewide offices or require an additional taxpayer-funded election for other offices.

No supporters or opponents were listed.

Proposition 37: Middle-Income Homebuyers

What it would do: Proposition 37 would authorize the California Housing Finance Agency to issue up to $25 billion in revenue bonds to create a homeownership assistance program. Eligible buyers could receive a loan covering up to 17% of the purchase price of a qualifying newly constructed home. Buyers would need to provide at least 3% of the purchase price as a down payment, be California residents, occupy the home and meet income requirements. The

home also would have to meet specified price requirements. The bonds would be repaid through homeowners' loan payments rather than state tax revenue, and the Legislative Analyst's Office estimates there would be no direct state or local government costs.

Support

Supporters, including the United Nurses Associations of California, California Conference of Carpenters and state Treasurer Fiona Ma, say the measure would make homeownership more attainable for middle-income Californians. They argue that down-payment requirements are a major barrier to homeownership and that the program could also encourage new home construction.

Opposition

No argument against Proposition 37 was submitted for the official voter guide.

Supporters

United Nurses Associations of CaliforniaCalifornia Conference of Carpenters Fiona Ma, California State Treasurer

No opponents were listed.

Proposition 38: Research Bond

What it would do:

PROP38 would authorize an $8.4 billion bond primarily for research into cancer, heart disease, Alzheimer's and other conditions that can be treated through immunotherapies. Half of the funding would go to a research institute affiliated with the University of California. The remaining half would be distributed among select public universities and nonprofits. Drugs developed through this research would have to be discounted by 20% for Californians, and 10% of revenue from those drugs would go to the state general fund.

Support

Supporters say immunotherapy research has significant potential because the immune system is involved in many diseases. They argue that additional funding is needed as the Trump administration has sought to reduce federal funding for health science research.

Opposition:

Critics say the measure focuses too narrowly on one area of biomedical research instead of a broader range of health research. They question whether research funded by the bond would ultimately produce commercial drugs, given the difficulty of bringing new drugs through the approval process and onto the market. Opponents also question why one nonprofit would receive half of the funding and say the bond would add an estimated $500 million to $600 million annually in debt payments for 20 years.

Supporters:

California Democratic Party Susan Disney Lord, Board Chair Alzheimers Los Angeles

Opponents:

Robert Kaplan, senior scholar at StanfordLeague of Women Voters

Proposition 39: Voter Identification

What it would do:

PROP39 would require voters to show government-issued identification at polling places and would require election officials to verify that registered voters are U.S. citizens. Voters casting mail-in ballots would have to provide the last four digits of a government-issued identification document, such as a driver's license number. California currently requires residents to provide identification and a Social Security number when registering to vote but does not require identification at polling places.

Support

Supporters argue that requiring ID at polling sites would strengthen public trust in California's election system. They point to the number of states that require some form of identification to vote.

Opposition

Opponents say requiring ID could make it more difficult for eligible voters who do not have a drivers license or other qualifying documents. They argue that the requirement could disproportionately affect people with disabilities, low incomes and people who have recently moved.

Supporters:

California Republican PartyMargit Whitlock, Democratic Coalition Chair Californians for Voter ID

Opponents:

California Democratic Party Darius Kemp, California State Director Common Cause

Proposition 40: Billionaire Tax

What it would do:

PROP40 would impose a one-time 5% tax on an estimated 200 Californians whose net worth exceeded $1 billion at the beginning of the year. The Service Employees International Union-United Healthcare Workers West, which sponsors the measure, projects that the tax would raise approximately $100 billion over five years. The money would be earmarked primarily for health care, with some funding reserved for food assistance and education.

If Proposition 41 or Proposition 42 receives more votes than Proposition 40, Proposition 40 would be nullified.

Support

Supporters argue that the people subject to the tax benefitted the most financially from recent federal tax changes. They point to federal cuts to Medicaid (Medi-Cal), which provides health coverage to low income residents. SEIU-UHW argues those cuts could lead to hospital and clinic closures, the loss of thousands of jobs and reduced access to health care.

Opposition:

Opponents include Silicon Valley entrepreneurs, business interests, and some health and labor organizations. They argued that the measure could cause billionaires to leave California, reducing tax revenue over the long term. Health organizations opposing the measure state they were not consulted in its development and argue that it does not address the long-term fiscal challenges facing health care. The same groups support Propositions 41 and 42, competing measures that would limit new special taxes.

Supporters:

California Democratic PartySuzanne Jimenez, Chief of Staff SEIU-United HealthCare Workers West

Opponents:

Planned ParenthoodFrancisco Silva, CEO California Primary Care Association

Proposition 41: Tax Audits and Spending Limits

What it would do: Proposition 41 would require the California State Auditor to review programs funded by new special taxes before certain voter-initiated tax measures appear on the ballot. It also would require recurring audits of programs funded by special taxes approved by voters or the Legislature after Jan. 1, 2026. The measure also would nullify state taxes enacted after Jan. 1, 2026, if those taxes exclude their revenue from the voter-approved state spending limit. The overall fiscal effect is unknown and would depend on future decisions by voters, lawmakers and other policymakers.

Support

Supporters, including the California Society of Certified Public Accountants, CalAsian Chamber of Commerce and California Taxpayers Association, say the measure would increase transparency and accountability for programs funded by new taxes. They argue that independent audits would allow taxpayers to track how tax revenue is being used and evaluate whether publicly funded programs are producing results.

Opposition

Opponents, including U.S. Sen. Bernie Sanders and SEIU United Healthcare Workers West, argue that the measure is connected to efforts to prevent a proposed tax on wealthy Californians. They say the measure could restrict the state's ability to raise revenue for health care and other services.

Supporters:

CA Society of Certified Public Accountants (CalCPAs)CalAsian Chamber of Commerce; California Taxpayers Association (CalTax)

Opponents:

US Senator Bernie Sanders; SEIU United Healthcare Workers West

Proposition 42: Property Taxes

What it would do:

Proposition 42 would prohibit new taxes on the ownership of assets such as investment accounts, business interests and personal property. Those assets are typically taxed when they are sold or generate income. Like Proposition 41, Proposition 42 would seek to block Proposition 40, the proposed wealth tax on billionaires. If Proposition 42 receives more votes than Proposition 40, Proposition 40 would be nullified, even if the billionaire tax receives a majority of votes.

Support

Those who back the measure argue that California should not tax people simply for owning or controlling retirement accounts, financial portfolios or valuable personal property such as art. They want to prevent taxes on unrealized gains, increases in the value of assets that have not been sold or generated taxable income, and warn that pensions

and retirement accounts could eventually be subject to taxes based on future value.

Opposition:

SEIU-United Healthcare Workers West, the sponsor of Proposition 40, is the chief opponent of Proposition 42. The union argues that PROP42 is intended to prevent California from imposing a wealth tax on billionaires. The union says the measure is not primarily about protecting everyday Californians from new taxes but about preventing a one-time tax on the wealth of billionaires.

Supporters:

Michael Hedes, President California Small Business Association Jennifer Yoder, Board Members California Senior Alliance

Opponents:

California Democratic PartySuzanne Jimenez, Chief of Staff SEIU-United HealthCare Workers West

Proposition 43: Local Taxes

What it would do: Proposition 43 would change the approval threshold for certain local special taxes proposed by voters. Beginning Jan. 1, 2027, new, increased or extended local special taxes placed on the ballot through voter signature gathering would require approval from at least two-thirds of voters instead of a simple majority. The measure would apply to taxes dedicated to specific purposes, such as certain taxes used to fund local services. The Legislative Analyst's Office says local government tax revenues could be lower in the future because of the higher approval threshold.

Support

Supporters, including the California Taxpayers Association, Family Business Association of California and California Hispanic Chambers of Commerce, say the measure would restore a two-thirds voter approval requirement for local special taxes and strengthen taxpayer protections. They argue that recent court decisions have allowed certain voter-proposed tax increases to pass with less than two-thirds approval.

Opposition

Opponents, including California Professional Firefighters, the California Federation of Teachers and the Nurse Alliance of SEIU California, argue that Proposition 43 would make it more difficult for communities to raise money for services such as fire protection, emergency response, roads, schools, hospitals and affordable housing. They say increasing the threshold would allow a minority of voters to block tax measures approved by a majority.

Supporters:

California Taxpayers AssociationFamily Business Association of CaliforniaCalifornia Hispanic Chambers of Commerce

Opponents:

California Professional FirefightersCalifornia Federation of TeachersNurse Alliance of SEIU CA.

Proposition 44: Clinic funding

What it would do:

Proposition 44 would require community clinics that serve low-income patients to spend 90% of their annual revenue on patient care. The measure would direct the attorney general to publish guidance defining which expenses qualify as patient-care spending and would allow the state to fine clinics that fail to meet the 90% requirement. The labor union SEIU-UHW supported a similar bill last year, but it failed. Clinics also unsuccessfully sought to keep the measure off the ballot through a lawsuit earlier this year.

Support

Supporters, led by SEIU-UHW, argue that community clinics should devote more money to direct patient care and less to executive compensation and overhead. With federal cuts under H.R.1 expected to leave more people uninsured, supporters say it is important for clinics to prioritize patient care.

Opposition:

Opponents say the measure is unnecessary because community clinics are already subject to extensive state and federal regulation. They argue that the measure could result in more than $1.7 billion in noncompliance fees during its first year, potentially forcing clinics to reduce services or close.

Supporters:

Shawna Brown, Initiative Proponent Brisa J. Barrera, Community Clinic Worker

Opponents:

California Hospital Association Eric Ball, MD, FAAP, President American Academy of Pediatrics, California

Proposition 45: Environmental review

What it would do:

PROP45 would overhaul the California Environmental Quality Act, the state's landmark environmental review law. Sponsored by the California Chamber of Commerce, the measure would allow developers to seek expedited review for projects designated as "essential." It would establish a 365-day limit for environmental reviews of those projects, including roads and bridges, housing, schools, broadband infrastructure and wildfire mitigation projects. The measure also would require courts to rule within 270 days on lawsuits involving the environmental review law.

Support:

The California Chamber of Commerce says the state's environmental review law is outdated and allows costly bureaucracy and frivolous litigation to delay development. The organization argues that those delays increase costs for taxpayers and consumers. Supporters say Proposition 45 would accelerate development while maintaining essential environmental protections.

Opposition:

Opponents argue that the state's environmental review law protects people and the environment from potentially harmful development. They say weakening the requirements would reduce agencies' ability to protect communities, increase costly litigation and limit their ability to enforce environmental protections. Opponents also argue that the long-term costs of poor planning would ultimately fall on agencies and taxpayers.

Supporters:

California Children's Hospital AssociationCalifornia Council for Affordable Housing

Opponents:

Communities for a Better EnvironmentCenter for Food Safety

For the Nov. 3, 2026, general election, county elections officials will begin mailing ballots Oct. 5, which also marks the beginning of the vote-by-mail early voting period. Secure ballot drop boxes will open Oct. 6. The last day to register to vote is Oct. 19, although same-day voter registration will be available at county elections offices or voting locations through Election Day. Vote centers in Voter's Choice Act counties will open for early in-person voting Oct. 24, and in-person early voting locations throughout California will be open beginning Saturday, Oct. 31. Election Day is Tuesday, Nov. 3, with polls open from 7 a.m. to 8 p.m. Voters must return their ballots by 8 p.m. Election Day, and mailed ballots must be postmarked no later than Election Day.

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